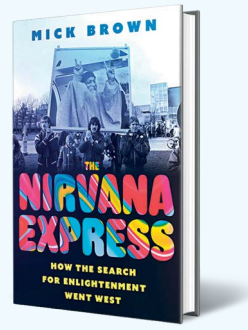
KARMA COLA

MICK BROWN'S *THE NIRVANA EXPRESS* IS A REVEALING ROMP THROUGH THE WEST'S SEARCH FOR SALVATION AS IT GOES SOUTH

to nosedive in a series of delusionary activities culminating in guns rather than roses.

The downward spiral was intimated in the first question a Harvard psychedelic "acid evangelist" was asked on arriving at a Himalayan ashram. Was he rich and, if so, would he buy them a Land Rover? As the exemplar of this "peace and not war" Flower Power era with its cash-on-delivery instant nirvana, the "Giggling Guru" of the Beatles could only teach them the *siddhi* of "levitating like frogs" when what they were lending their brand to was the expectation of eternal life. The "Oceanic" last guru outdoing all his predecessors in "letting it all hang out" proved adventurous far beyond the austerities normally associated with his Jain background: rubber gloves were supplied for free sex.

Mick Brown's romp concentrates on the masala rather than the sociology of the Hippie drang nach osten. Driven by the fear of nuclear extinction and facilitated by cheap flights (under the stern gaze of beefy Aeroflot air hostesses), *firangs* flocked to Manali, Goa and Hampi smoking pot and discovering the meaning of the universe, only to forget it the next morning. Flying west to the US, the holy hustlers' 'angrezi' was so rudimentary, one Godman was booed off the stage when he proclaimed "No sex" when what he meant was "No sects"!



THE NIRVANA EXPRESS
How the Search for Enlightenment Went West
By Mick Brown
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A new rate list to awaken the New World to the pricelessness of the guru-shishya relationship was devised and henceforth, interviews with the guru would cost $500 for the first hour and $100 every 10 minutes thereafter. Those who aspired to join the guru's commune had to contribute a $10,000 sweetener to the Treasury of Enlightenment skilled in dodging the tax authorities. It was the latter checking out the "Rich Man Guru's" 90-plus Rolls Royces, diamond watches and automatic rifles that soured the hedonist Utopia and clipped the wings of its spiritual highfliers. Reassuringly for those who remain Hippie at heart, in spite of the crash-landing, they "wouldn't have missed the experience for anything". ■

Bill Aitken

At a time when Hindu revivalism is on the rise on the embers of 20th-century nationalism, the focus on Banaras emerges with a raw intensity in Radhika Iyengar's study of the human toll that it also extracts. Her close interaction with the sect known as the Doms, the designated human despatchers of the Hindu dead on the famous burning ghats of Banaras, resonates with a clamour that is as compelling as the blowing of a hundred conches at the water's edge.

Iyengar's strength is that while she views the Dom community through the prism of caste, she does so with a rare sensitivity

It's fascinating to read of the minutiae of the lives of the families of the Doms in the years between 2016 and up to the present as observed by Iyengar's journalistic eye, compared to that of the celebrated Japanese writer Yukio Mishima (1925–1970). In his novel *Temple of the Dawn*, part of a tetralogy called *The Sea of Fertility*, Mishima is looking for salvation in the aftermath of Japan's catastrophic defeat in the Second World War. His protagonist Honda arrives at Banaras, "the holy of holies, the Jerusalem of the Hindus". On entering the charnel house of the burning ghats, he watches the Doms shovelling bits of wood over the body as it twists and contorts in the heat. Mishima writes: "...having witnessed the extremes he had, he knew that he should never recover from the shock".

Iyengar is, however, made of sterner stuff. She registers every bit of the horror of the actual lives of the Doms in their ghetto trapped with their wives and children. She records the physical toll on the men tasked with the actual process of cremating the dead and watches how their sons are initiated into the job at an early age.

The deceased are merchandise in the City of the Dead. Every part of the sacred journey with its age-old rituals has a price. Each component is dedicated to a different group of people. They guard their privilege with a zeal that binds them as tightly as the cords around the corpse waiting to enter the next stage of the karmic cycle.

The Doms are tasked, or cursed, to open those doors that will liberate the souls into their next life. Their reward is to be kicked down to the lowest rung of the caste spectrum. Iyengar's strength is that while she views the Dom community through the prism of caste, she does so with a rare sensitivity. She allows both the women she interviews and the younger generation a degree of freedom from oppression.

Tourism, the Internet, cellphones that connect Iyengar with her subjects long after she has left, mobility both through educational opportunities and two-wheelers that allow the young men to seek opportunities outside the rat-trap of their destiny, have made inroads into the ramparts of Fort Banaras. As Banaras reinvents itself as a Las Vegas with its daily spectacle of the synchronised Ganga Aarti rather than a tired old Jerusalem, Iyengar's thesis brims with a singular ray of light. ■

Geeta Doctor